

How Your Commute Ended Up Kicking the Dog

Draft, awaiting author approval. Not posted.

Subject lines

1. You snapped at the door. The dog paid for it.
2. When the whole house is off, check who came home last
3. How five words about the dishwasher ruined dinner

A bad day at work can make it all the way through your house and finish on the dog before dinner's on the table. You don't even have to yell. One snap at the front door does it. Nothing dramatic, just edges, and the rest of the house takes it from there without you. Most of us know what it's like to walk into somebody else's bad mood. This time the mood that wrecked the evening came in with you, and by the time it reached the dog you were upstairs changing your shirt.

You've just spent forty minutes behind a truck that brakes for every shadow, right after a meeting that should have been an email. You come through the door with your jaw still set. She asks if you called about the dishwasher. You say "I said I'd do it" in a voice that means you didn't, and also that the subject is closed. That's the whole offense, and you know it. She goes back to the kitchen, where the kids are supposedly doing homework. The next thing she says is "Feet. Off the table. Now," in a tone she didn't have at four o'clock. Your oldest gets told twice about his math, so he tells his little sister to get out of his room. His sister, now out of people smaller than her, shoves the dog off the couch with her foot. The dog did nothing. He spent the afternoon asleep in a patch of sun and has no opinion about the dishwasher.

Nobody in that house decided to hand it on. She wasn't punishing the kids, and they

weren't punishing the dog. It just went from one person to the next until there was nobody left. That's how your seven-year-old ends up in timeout over a meeting she wasn't in.

Marcus Aurelius was a Roman emperor who kept a private journal through years of war and plague. He wrote a lot about the part of a man that decides what a moment means. His *Meditations*, in the Haines translation, puts it this way at 6.8: "The ruling Reason it is that can arouse and deflect itself, make itself whatever it will, and invest everything that befalls with such a semblance as it wills."

He's saying the part of you in charge can wind itself up or settle itself down. It also decides what a lousy commute means once you're home. The truck and the meeting weren't your call. What they turned into at your front door was.

Her mood is hers, and the kids' moods are theirs. Some nights the evening really does

start with her long day, or with a kid who got left out at recess. What you bring through the door is yours. When the whole house is off around seven-thirty, the first question most of us reach for is who's being difficult. A better one is when it started and who was standing there. Going back one person at a time takes you about ten seconds. The dog got it from the youngest, the youngest got it from her brother, and he got it in the kitchen. Sometimes it ends at her day or at the school, and then you know something about her afternoon you didn't know at six. A lot of nights, if you're honest, it ends in the front hall at 6:15, with a guy still holding his car keys.

The dog, meanwhile, is back on his bed by the front door, waiting to see who walks in next.

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You don't have to yell to wreck a whole evening. One snap at the front door, nothing dramatic, just edges, and it gets all the way through the house to the dog by dinner. Nobody decided to hand it on. The dog did nothing.

[Substack link]

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She asks if you called about the dishwasher. You say "I said I'd do it" in a voice that closes the subject. Forty minutes later your youngest is shoving the dog off the couch and getting sent to her room for it.

[Substack link]

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When the whole house is off by seven-thirty, most of us start by asking who's being difficult. The better question is when it started and who was standing in the front hall. Some nights it's her long day or a rough one at school. A lot of nights it's a guy still holding his car keys.

[Substack link]

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A bad day at work can make it all the way through your house and finish on the dog before dinner's on the table. You don't have to yell for that. One short answer at the front door does it, and everybody after you hands it along without meaning to. The dog, for the record, did nothing. Full piece: [Substack link]

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A Calm House Doesn't Prove You're a Calm Guy

Draft, awaiting author approval. Not posted.

Subject lines

1. Your quiet month at home proved less than you think
2. What to notice when a hard week lands on you both
3. Who are you to her at 2 a.m. with a sick kid?

Staying calm in a quiet house doesn't prove you're a calm guy. It might just mean it's been a quiet month. Plenty of us have had one of those stretches and decided, privately, that we'd finally got this patience thing down. Nobody's sick, work is fine, the kids are asleep by eight, and you catch yourself thinking you've turned into a pretty even-keeled guy. Call it fair-weather patience. There's nothing wrong with it, except that nobody has asked it to do anything yet.

Then the week shows up. The youngest gets the stomach bug at 2 a.m., and by breakfast the middle one has it too. The car starts making the noise, the one that sounds expensive. Your mom calls Wednesday, very cheerful, to say the doctor just wants a few more tests. Nobody in the house has slept more than four hours, and that includes both of you. The dishwasher has been full of clean dishes since Monday because neither of you has had ninety seconds to empty it. That week came from nowhere in particular. It landed on both of you at once, which is why it's the only week that tells you anything.

Epictetus was a Stoic teacher who spent his early life as a slave and his later years running a school. His short handbook on living opens with one plain line, in George Long's translation: "Of things some are in our power, and others are not." Put simply, some things belong to you and some never did. Then he

sorts things into two lists. Yours is short. It holds what you think, what you want, what you avoid, and what you do. Other people's moods aren't on it. The body is on the other list, so the stomach bug was never yours to control, and the quiet month wasn't either. Patience that only shows up when everything outside you cooperates was built on the wrong list.

Finding out which kind of calm you have takes one bad week and a little attention. The next time something real lands, the tell is usually small. For a lot of men it's a sentence that starts with "Can everybody just." Or she asks whether anyone called the pharmacy, and you answer like she asked it to annoy you. She's on the same four hours you are. None of that makes you a bad husband. It means the patience was on loan from the quiet month, and the month wants it back. The other kind is plainer than you'd expect. You're tired and

you're worried about your mom, and you still hear her question as a question. She's finding out the same thing about herself, by the way, in front of the same full dishwasher.

The car, for the record, is still making the noise.

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Option 1 (counterintuitive)

Staying calm in a quiet house doesn't prove you're a calm guy. It might just mean it's been a quiet month. The week that counts is the one with the stomach bug, the car noise and nobody sleeping more than four hours.

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Option 2 (story-led)

Nobody's sick, work is fine, the kids are asleep by eight, and you decide you've finally got this patience thing down. Then the youngest throws up at 2 a.m. and the car starts making the noise. By Thursday you hear yourself say "Can everybody just."

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Option 3 (practical)

The tell is usually small. She asks whether anyone called the pharmacy, and you answer like she asked it to annoy you. She's running on the same four hours of sleep you are.

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Plenty of us have had an easy month and quietly decided we'd finally got patience figured out. Then the week arrives with a sick kid, a too-cheerful phone call from your mom and nobody in the house sleeping more than four hours. That week lands on both of you, and it's the only one that tells you what kind of calm you actually have. Full piece: [Substack link]

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You Read Some Stoicism and Went Behind Glass

Draft, awaiting author approval. Not posted.

Subject lines

1. Feeling as bad as she does won't help her
2. The first ten seconds after she tells you something hard
3. What she sees when you nod through her awful week

If you've read a little Stoicism, there's a decent chance you've tried the version where you turn into a very calm houseplant. She tells you about her awful week and you nod slowly, like she's walking you through a quarterly report you didn't ask to see. You're calm, sure. You're also no help to her at all, and she can tell. Somewhere between the reading and the couch, a lot of us decided steady meant watching her from behind glass.

The opposite mistake looks a lot more loving. She's fried, so you get fried with her. You sigh

in all the right places and get angrier at her boss than she is. By nine o'clock you're both at the kitchen table feeling terrible. That feels like being on her side. In practice, two people in a low is a lower low. She brought you one bad week. Now she has her week plus your reaction to it, and your reaction is one more thing she has to manage. It works the same in the other direction. When you're the one having the awful week, what helps is someone in the room who stays kind and level while you're low.

The Stoics were Greek and Roman philosophers from about two thousand years ago. They put a lot of weight on the part of you that decides what a moment means and what you do about it. Keeping that part in charge was most of the work, and it was never a way to care less. Say she's sick, the miserable kind, and you walk in with soup. You're warm. You make one small, quiet joke

that lightens the room without brushing off how bad she feels. You're not swept into her misery, and you're not performing cool from across the room either. You're just steady, and that steadiness turns out to be the thing you brought her, along with the soup.

The next time she tells you something hard, a lot gets decided in the first ten seconds. In the nodding version, your eyes stay where they were and you wait for her to finish. The warm version is mostly small physical stuff. You turn around from the counter and put the phone face down. You sit close enough that your knee touches hers. Then you say one thing back that proves you caught the specific part. "Wait, the same person who approved it is now blaming you for it?" The joke waits until she's had a while to be mad out loud, and it's aimed at the situation or at you. It takes about ten seconds and no speeches.

The soup can come from a can.

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Option 1 (counterintuitive)

Getting just as upset as she is feels like loyalty. Two people in a low is a lower low. Now she's handling her bad week and your reaction to it.

[Substack link]

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Option 2 (story-led)

She tells you about her awful week. You nod slowly, like she's walking you through a quarterly report. Very calm. No help at all.

[Substack link]

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Option 3 (practical)

The next time she tells you something hard, the first ten seconds do most of the work. You turn around from the counter, the phone goes face down, and you sit close enough that your knee touches hers. The joke can wait.

[Substack link]

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FACEBOOK

A lot of us read a little Stoicism and decided being steady meant staying calm and a little far away. So she tells you about her hard week and gets a very polite nod. The better version is soup when she's sick and one small joke that makes the room lighter without brushing her off. It's steady and warm at the same time, and it starts in about ten seconds.

Full piece: [Substack link]

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